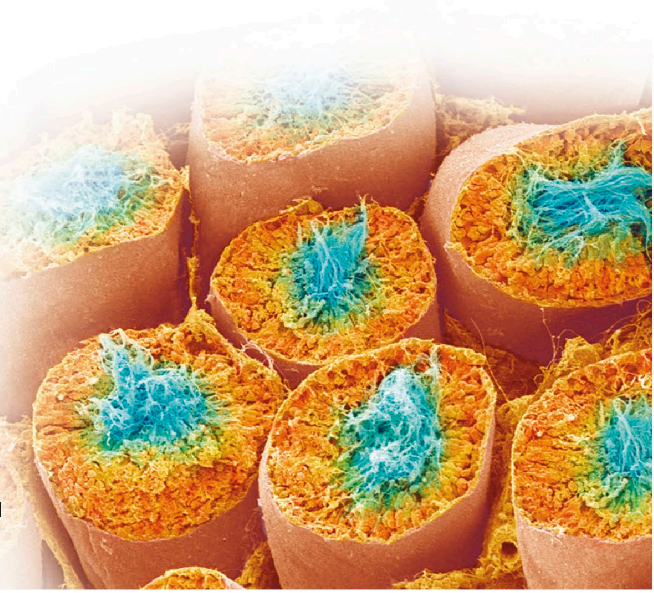
SPERM PRODUCTION

Sperm develop in the seminiferous tubules of the testes. Sperm cells gradually move away from the supporting cells and mature as they pass through the seminiferous tubule and epididymis. The process takes about 74 days.



MATURING SPERM
This cross-section through several seminiferous tubules in the testis shows maturing sperm with tails in the centre (blue).

MALE HORMONE CONTROL

Hormone production is often regulated by feedback (see p.139), when the amount of a substance controls how much of it is made. The testes, hypothalamus, and pituitary gland control production of sperm and male hormones in this way. Gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH) from the hypothalamus stimulates the pituitary to control testis function via follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH) and luteinizing hormone (LH). High levels of testosterone act on the pituitary to slow the release of LH and FSH.